

About KiCad

Type: EDA

Initial Release: 1992

Latest stable release: BZR-4022 on July 7, 2013

Coded in: C++

Licence: GNU GPL v2, GNU LGPL v2.1

Operating systems: Linux, Microsoft Windows and Mac OS X (experimental)

Disk space required: 197MB (for Windows), 268MB (for UBUNTU)

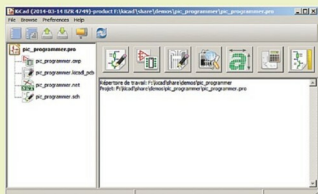


Fig. 1: Main window



Fig. 2: Utility launch pane

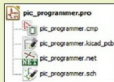


Fig. 3: Project tree view

tary libraries, manufacturing files for photo-tracing, drilling and automatic component

KiCad's graphical user interface

The main KiCad window (Fig. 1) is composed of a project tree view, a launch pane containing buttons used to run the various software tools and a message window. The menu and the toolbar can be used to create, read and save project files.

KiCad allows you to run all standard software tools that come with it. The launch pane (Fig. 2) is made of the seven buttons that correspond to the following commands (from left to right): 1 – Eeschema, 2 – Cypcb, 3 – Pcbnew, 4 – Gerbview, 5 – Bitmap2component, 6 – Pcb calculator, 7 – PI Editor.

Each project has a project tree view (see Fig. 3). Double-clicking on the

Eeschema icons runs the schematic editor, which in this case will open the file 'pic_programmer.sch.' Double-clicking on the Pcbnew icon runs the layout editor, in this case opening the file 'pic_programmer.kicad_pcb.' Right clicking on any of the files in the project tree allows generic files manipulation. KiCad top toolbar (Fig. 4) allows for some basic files operation (from left to right).

Download and install KiCad

KiCad runs on Linux, Apple OS X and Windows. You can download a copy of KiCad from:

http://kicad.sourceforge.net/wiki/Main_Page

Installation instructions are available on the KiCad website under: *Info/Install*.

Whatever installation method you choose, always go for a recent version of KiCad.

Under Linux. Under Linux, the easiest way to install KiCad is via Aptitude. Type into your terminal:

```
sudo add-apt-repository ppa:paxer/ppa
sudo aptitude update && sudo aptitude
safe-upgrade
sudo aptitude install KiCadKiCad-
doc-en
```

At the time of writing, the standard apt-get repository of Ubuntu offers a version of KiCad which is about one year old. Alternatively, you can download and install a pre-compile version of KiCad, or directly download the source code, compile and install KiCad.

Under Apple OS X. At the time of writing, the best way to install KiCad on Apple OS X was to download a pre-build binary from:

<http://kicad.sourceforge.net/wiki/Downloads>

Note. Installation files for only Linux and Windows platforms are available in the DVD that accompanies this issue of Electronics For You Plus. ●

The author is a senior technical correspondent at EFY. The article has inputs from KiCad's latest documentation released on March 17, 2014

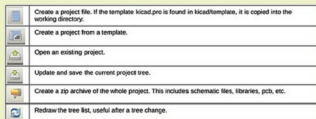


Fig. 4: Top toolbar

placement files, it is recommended to create a project as follows:

1. Create a working directory for the project (using KiCad or by other means).

2. In this directory, use KiCad to create a project file (file with extension .pro) via the 'Start a new project' icon.

It is strongly recommended to use the same name for both project files